Drums, Girls and Dangerous Pie – "Fever"

By Jordan Sonnenblick

If you've never been dragged out of a middle-school dance by your mom, while she's wearing sweatpants and carrying your pajama-clad little brother over her shoulder, then you haven't had the same kind of life I'm leading this year.

INTRODUCTION

It's difficult to explain sickness, and even more so to accept and cope with it. Quite often those who play the audience in a sickness of a loved one have it the worst. A boy struggles with his baby brother's cancer in "Fever" by Jordan Sonnenblick.

As she rushed me to the car at breakneck speed, my mom told me what was going on:

We're going to the emergency room. Your brother has a fever.

I looked at the top of Jeffrey's sleeping head, and even in the dim school hallway lights I could see that his hair was all matted with sweat.

Why is that an emergency? What does it mean? Where's Dad?

Dad is still at his dinner. I don't know the name of the restaurant and his cell phone might be turned off. Any time your brother gets a fever from now on it's an emergency. I don't know what this means. Get the door please.

OK. Mom, is this serious?

I don't know honey. I don't know. I wish I knew.

She must have thought the situation was pretty urgent, though, because she usually won't leave the house in sweats, and I noticed she hadn't even taken the time to put shoes on Jeffrey. Also, she's the careful driver in our family on most days, but our ride to the hospital was like the Indy 500. I didn't even have time to

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think of how in the world I was going to explain this away to my friends on Monday -I was mostly too busy trying to keep from passing out from the incredible G-forces every time we turned a corner. Somehow, Jeffrey didn't wake up, but he was definitely groaning in his sleep. I reached over and crammed his blanket between his head and the corner of his booster seat so he wouldn't get whipped around so much; my hand brushed against his forehead, and he was definitely ragingly hot.

The ER staff didn't mess around at all when we got there. As soon as my mom said the word "leukemia," there were doctors, nurses, and technicians swarming all over. The doctor in charge was barking orders like a Marine drill sergeant.

As they started to take Jeffrey's clothes off: he woke up. I guess he wasn't surprised to find himself in a hospital - both he and my mother seemed to have become used to this bizarre world. I couldn't even understand what the doctors and nurses were saying, but they were both clued in to this secret language. He didn't say anything as they took his temperature orally, even though he used to always make a big show of choking when my parents did it at home. He responded to all of the commands that came his way - *Tilt your head! Take three deep breaths! Lean forward,* -with mute obedience. Until they laid him down, and went for his chest with a needle. Now, I knew that something had been done to Jeffrey's chest in Philadelphia; I had seen the two lines of stitches, and the round bulge under the skin of his ribs. But during the whole period up until that night, the medical stuff had only sunk in to a point; I only accepted what I had to accept to make sense of any given moment. So I only really knew that he was taking steroids every day, for example, when I saw him gagging down the syringes of bitter liquid in the kitchen every morning and night. And I guess now was my moment to believe

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in the Port-a-Cath, which was an IV tube that had been surgically implanted under the skin a couple of inches above Jeffrey's right nipple.

Jeffrey pulled away from the doctor when he saw the needle, and asked in a little pathetic voice:

Can't we do the emm-lah?

I didn't know it then, but EMLA is a cream that makes your skin numb. They had been using EMLA so Jeffrey wouldn't feel the hurt of the needle as it stabbed through his skin to get at the catheter in his chest.

The doctor's voice softened then, and he almost whispered to Jeffrey:

I'm sorry, Buddy. The EMLA takes an hour to work, and we can't wait. Then the doctor half-turned to me, and asked Jeffrey: *Would it help if your brother held your band?*

Jeffrey didn't respond at all, but he looked at me, and his eyes were brimming. I am pretty squeamish about shots and blood and stuff, but what was I going to do? I grabbed his hand, and let him sort of lean his head on my shoulder without sitting up from his pillow. I started the "You're OK, Jeffy" chant, and a nurse scrubbed the circle of skin over the port with yellowish-orange stuff. Then she broke open one of those sterile packets that needles come in, and took out a truly large one, which was bent in the middle at a ninety-degree angle. Jeffrey started to whimper, and the tears began to soak the shoulder of my shirt, but he didn't even flinch as the huge needle jabbed straight into his chest. The nurse taped the needle in place, and I closed my eyes. I heard someone say, "Flushing the port," and then I got a little woozy. Jeffrey kept squeezing my hand really hard for a few minutes, until the blood specimens had all been taken and an IV line was hooked up to his port. I think we both fell asleep for a little while then. When I opened my

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eyes, the doctor was talking with my mom; neither of them noticed I was awake, so I just lay there and listened. Evidently, Jeffrey had what should have been a simple ear infection, but his white blood cell counts were low because of the chemotherapy drugs he was on, so his body couldn't fight off germs very well. The doctor was saying that Jeffrey would need to spend a few days in the hospital getting antibiotics through his IV line in addition to his regular chemo medicines. My mom didn't look pleased.

Can we do it here, or does he --

He'll be here until morning. We'll put him on a pediatric floor for now, but we're going to have to transport him to a Children's Hospital in Philadelphia and soon to get his fever down.

Transport him?

Yes, we can send him in an ambulance so we don't have to stop the IV, or we can cap the line and have you drive him. I'll consult with the specialist in the morning and see what he thinks is best.

Oh, God. How costly is an ambulance?

I don't know, but we have to do whatever's best for your son medically right now.

I understand. It's just, we're in some financial trouble with all of this…

My mom started crying then.

I'm sorry Doctor, it's just all this, all of a sudden, you know? We have very good insurance, but things add up. My husband isn't…taking it well…

I hear you, Ma 'am. He sort of patted my mom on the shoulder at this point. *I'll be back around in a few hours –we'll move you all up to a private room any minute now, and then maybe you can try and get some rest.*

Yeah, sure. My mom looked tired enough to sleep for a week, but I knew she

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wasn't going to get any rest.

I got out of Jeffrey's bed for the big move upstairs, and fell back asleep in a chair by the window of the new room. My mom spent a few hours lying on a cot they had brought in, but I really don't think you could say she slept. Every hour or so some medical person or another came in to take Jeffrey's temperature, or attach a new bag to his IV, or do something that would ruin our rest.

At 2 a.m., my mom walked out of the room. I wanted to know what was going on, so after a couple of minutes, I followed her. I found her sitting in the hallway, leaning back on the wall with her knees to her chest, holding a cup of coffee that must have come from the little coin-operated machine that was out there. 1 plopped down next to her.

Hey, Mom. How are ya?

I'm fine, Steven. I was really worried about your brother last night. But it looks like this is just what it's going to be like…for a while.

Mom, how long is this going to last?

They're going to run some nests next week. If he's cancer-free by then, he'll still be in treatment for a few years. Then, who knows?

After five years without any, he should be totally normal.

Mom, what if he's not cancer-free next week?

I don't know Steven. I just don't know. By the way, I'm sorry that we ruined your night.

Mom, forget it. It was fine.

Oh, really? Fine, was it? Should I storm into your graduation wearing sweats too?

Yeah, that would be pretty cool. Maybe you could have your hair up in curlers

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for extra style points?

I might be able to do that Steven. How about some flip-flops on my feet?

Excellent, Mom. That would be excellent.

Right there in the hallway, I put my head in her lap. She stroked my hair for a while, and then she sent me back into the room:

Get some sleep, pal.

At about five in the morning, my dad came into the room and shook me awake (I guess my mom had gotten through to him by phone at some point). He put a finger over his lips so I wouldn't make noise and wake Jeffrey, but of course, right when I was about to tiptoe out of the room, a lady came crashing in with the giant breakfast cart. So we had this odd little family conference while Jeffrey attempted to choke down some food. My parents spent a few minutes looking at Jeffrey's hospital chart, worked out the details of what needed to be done if my mom and Jeffrey were going to Philadelphia for a week, and went out into the hall to argue about something. I had a little while alone with Jeffrey. He looked really exhausted, but his fever was gone, and he was much more alert mentally than he'd been the night before. He asked me about my dance:

Did you have fun? Did you dance a lot? Did Renee Albert kiss you? Did it feel gross?

Get out of here, you little nut-ball. I'm telling you, I have zero chance of kissing Renee Albert. Zero. Zilch. Nada.

So who DID you kiss?

Nobody. I was just standing around with my friends when you came to get me.

Did I ruin your night?

Mom asked me that, too. Jeffy, you didn't ruin my night. It was ruined from the

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start. You had a worse night than I did, anyway.

Oh, well. At least you didn't have to kiss anybody.

Yes, Jeffy, that's a big comfort to me.

My parents came back in, and I started to get up and leave. Jeffrey asked me for a hug, and I gave him one.

Take care Jeffy, I'll see you soon, right? Just remember not to throw food at the nurses. I don't want to get any complaint calls, OK?

Steven, I don't throw food at…oh, it was a joke, right?

Yup, buddy boy. It was a joke. But seriously, no kissing the nurses on their lips, either. It messes up their makeup.

Eeeeeeewwwww!

It was about 7 a.m. when my Dad and I got home. I somehow made it to my bed, and collapsed into a near coma that lasted until I got too hungry to sleep through lunchtime. It was probably noon or so when I made it to the kitchen. My dad was sitting there, looking stubbly and worn-down, eating a bagel without much of an expression on his face. He gave me a tiny nod that was almost business-like -totally neutral, like he wasn't really seeing me. I got out cereal and milk, and it was so quiet between us that I was getting grossed out by the distinct sounds of our food-chewing processes. As soon as I finished, I went downstairs to play the drums. And play the drums. And play the drums. I played through all of the basic rudiments, and then did all of my lesson pages for the week. Then I put five CDs in the changer behind my drums, put on my headphones, pressed "SHUFFLE," and played along with at least ten really loud metal songs in a row without stopping.

I looked up in the middle of a Led Zeppelin drum solo, and my dad was sitting on the beat-up old couch about eight feet in front of my bass drum. Because he

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startled me pretty badly, and because I figured he was probably about 43% deaf if he had been sitting there a while, I jumped up and whipped off the headphones.

Uhhh . . . hi, Dad.

I just got the call from your mother. They're taking Jeffrey to Philadelphia in about two hours. She wants us to get his stuff together for him. Do you know what toys and clothed he likes? Can you help me?

My dad looked ashamed at this, like he had asked me to steal him a bottle of Jack Daniels or something.

Sure, Dad.

Hey, you're been down here playing for a while now. Are you all right?

I couldn't believe my father was just now noticing me, and that I might be upset about my brother's situation.

I'm fine, Dad.

Oh, your mother thought you seemed upset at the emergency room, and when they put the tubes in . . .

Dad, they didn't just put tubes in. They stabbed him in the chest. They STABBED him!

I was stunned by what happened next, although I had to admit it was becoming a pretty common occurrence: I started to cry. And once I started, I couldn't stop. My dad wasn't necessarily going to win the Teddy Bear Society's Father of the Year Award, but for the first time in weeks, he reacted. He put his arm around my shoulders, and sort of squeezed me in. We must have stayed like that for a good twenty minutes, until I couldn't postpone blowing my nose anymore. I picked my head up off of my dad, walked over to the other end of the sofa, got a tissue, and blew my nose. Then I sat right back down by him. We stared at each other without

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having any concept of what to do or say next. My dad finally broke the silence with an old family punch line: *So, uhhh, how about those Knicks?*

We chuckled awkwardly, but at least it was a chuckle.

Then we went upstairs and packed up Jeffrey's stuff. On the drive over to the hospital, I had an odd realization: this was the first time in weeks that I had laughed with each member of my family within a 24-hour period.

At the hospital, Jeffrey was looking fairly worried. My mom was out in the hall, arguing with the doctors in Philly on her cell phone. My dad stayed to talk with her, and I went right to my brother.

Hey, Jeffy, how ya feelin?

I'm okay. We had oatmeal for breakfast but it wasn't as good as yours. I'm scared.

What are you scared about?

Mommy said that they might have to do another bone marrow tomorrow. It was supposed to be next time, but now it's tomorrow. The bone marrow HURTS. And I might still be very sick if they give it to me early. They said they would do it in a month, and all the bad stuff should be gone. But what if they aren't gone yet? Then they have to give me more throw-up medicine. It's NO FAIR!

Jeffy, I'm sure the doctors know what they're doing. They wouldn't do the bone marrow this early unless they thought it would be OK.

But it might not be OK It might realty really not.

Well, buddy, you're in luck. Check out what I brought you. And with a flourish, I pulled his favorite Rescue Hero action figure out of his bag. *Look! It's Matt Medic. He's here to protect you.*

Matt Medic, I'm scared.

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Don't he frightened, young man.

He always loved it when I pretended to be one of his toys, and Matt Medic was perfect for the occasion. He carried a huge plastic paramedic pack and a giant gun-like thing that we always pretended was some kind of vaccine syringe.

But what if I'm still very sick?

Well, son, let's concentrate on my Matt Medic Shot Shooter. It's full of magic anti-hurt stuff - guaranteed to save your bone marrow. Here we go.

And I used Matt Medic to give Jeffrey a "shot."

That ought to do it. Just remember, you never have to worry when Matt Medic is on the watch. And one other thing: don't kiss the nurses. It gets them in trouble!

My parents came into the room then, and we had the whole obligatory hugs-and-farewells scene. It was fairly touching, all things considered. We said we'd be back together again soon, and that everything would be fine, and at that moment, everyone in the family was united toward the common goal of getting Jeffrey well.

The last thing I said to Jeffrey was: *I'll see you in no time, pal. Just remember to listen to Matt Medic, and there will be no trouble!* As things would turn out, though, there would be a lot more of both time and trouble before we were all in one room again.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier - Serious Prose
2007 National Qualifier - Serious Prose
2009 National Qualifier - Serious Prose

2007 National Qualifier – Dramatic Interpretation for a Male

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